

What is a project life cycle?

Every project moves through the project life cycle. The project life cycle is a basic framework that Project Managers and teams use to effectively structure projects and set them up for success.

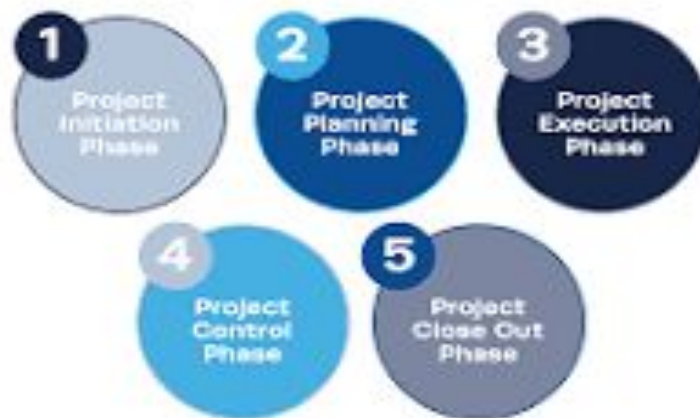
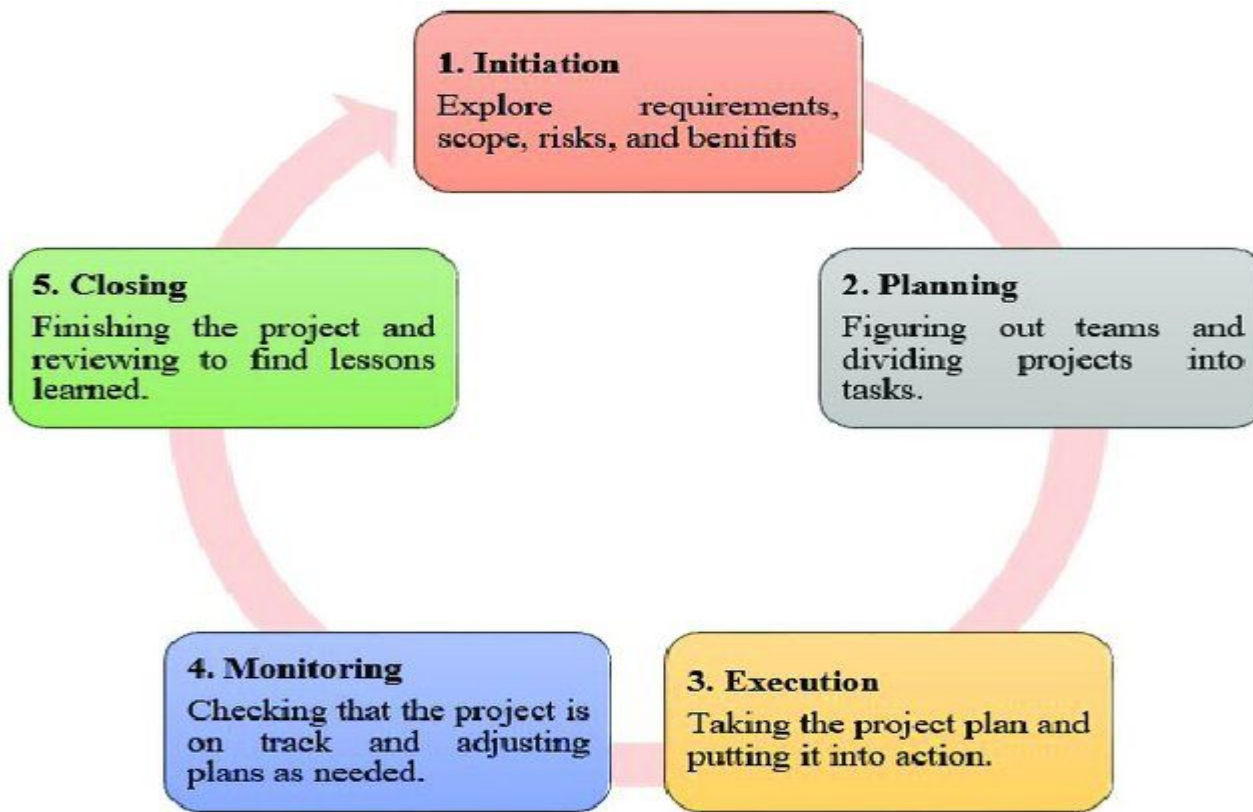
Project Life Cycle Phases

Within the project life cycle are a handful of different phases—or collections of logically related project activities that culminates in the completion of one or more deliverables.

Some of the most common names for these phases include:

- **Feasibility** — Determines if the business case is valid and if the organization has the capability to deliver the intended outcome.
- **Design** — Planning and analysis lead to the design of a project's deliverable(s).
- **Build** — Construction of the deliverable(s) with integrated quality assurance activities.
- **Test** — Final quality review and inspection of deliverables are carried out before transition, go-live, or customer acceptance.
- **Deploy** — Project deliverables are put into use and transitional activities required for sustainment, benefits realization, and organizational change management are completed.
- **Close** — The project is closed, project knowledge and artifacts are archived, project team members are released, and contracts are closed.

Note: Project management process groups are not project phases.



This cycle includes clear phases: **initiation, planning, execution, monitoring and controlling, and closure**

The 5 phases of a project life cycle

Understanding the five project management life cycle phases and their requirements will give you a repeatable, improvable framework for effective project management.

Phase 1: Initiation

The initiation phase of the project life cycle is where a project's feasibility and value are assessed before any detailed planning or execution begins. During this phase, the project's objectives, scope, purpose, and stakeholders are defined.

Key activities typically include:

- Developing a business case
- Conducting a feasibility study
- Identifying stakeholders
- Creating a project charter or brief that formally authorizes the project

Phase 2: Planning

During the planning phase in the project life cycle, a project roadmap is created for completing the work on time and in line with your success criteria, all without going over budget.

In this stage, you'll break your project into smaller tasks, set milestones and [manage deadlines](#), and create detailed plans for resources, schedules, tools, and task assignments.

Some of the items you might create in the planning phase include:

- **Project management plan:** Specify the project phases and tasks with a [work breakdown structure](#) and Gantt chart to outline task dependencies and timelines.
- **Risk plan:** Predict potential risks and create standard operating procedures around who owns each issue.
- **Financial plan:** Create and allocate a budget across teams and resource types.
- [Resource plan](#): Identify team members you need and assign roles, while centralizing essential resources.
- **Communication plan:** Choose the channel(s) to communicate with your team and clients, or if [Loom Screen Recordings](#) can cut unnecessary meetings.
- **Quality plan:** Establish KPIs and define how you'll measure your team's performance and outputs.

Phase 3: Execution

The [project execution](#) phase is where you implement the project plan and complete the project deliverables. As the project manager, your responsibilities may require you to:

- Assign tasks
- Clarify roles
- Answer questions
- Oversee work
- Facilitate communication
- Attend briefings and meetings
- Support your team

Handling the day-to-day demands of complex project execution is no easy feat. Instead, you have to allow your team to focus on delivering work rather than struggling with spreadsheets and disjointed tools. The biggest challenge for project managers is preventing all the tiny details from slipping through the cracks. Centralize all your work in one place so you understand how each task impacts the timeline and budget. And there's no doubting project challenges when there are elaborate tasks or multiple teams involved. That's exactly why Matt Chester, Senior System Engineer at [Reddit](#), invited design and branding teams to work with engineers within a centralized platform. "Cross-functional teams have found it easier to work with developers and technical teams in Atlassian because they don't have to switch tools to create or manage tickets," Matt says. "By centralizing tooling, they can now work in one place, see metrics about their work, and make it easier for people to interface with them."

Phase 4: Monitoring and controlling

In this phase, you'll track project progress and make adjustments to ensure the project stays on track.

Collect information from timesheets, reports, and team members.

Always stay on top of your project's progress by using timeline views in your project management software.

Whether it's a [Gantt Chart](#) or [Kanban board](#), you must identify when things are off track against your project roadmap.

In a recent episode of the [Projectified](#) podcast from the Project Management Institute, Adam Motiwala, a product manager at Google, shared the challenges restoring order with communication. He explained how project managers need to control projects by understanding personalities and trust.

"Just like any relationship, communication is very critical," Adam says. "If you don't communicate, that's when the friction happens. And just like any relationship you have to have that trust."

As the project manager, your job is not to assume, but take action. This is the controlling aspect of this phase. Successful project managers reinforce the life cycle of project by controlling aspects like:

- Timelines:** If a team member can't complete a task on time, you must assign it to someone else.
- Cost:** If a vendor cost is higher than anticipated, you need to immediately reduce the project scope.
- Team:** If there's a disagreement between two team members, you have the last word to resolve it.
- Quality:** If a part of the product is substandard, you create a different approach to build it.
- Risk:** If an unforeseen risk emerges, you mitigate it before it affects the entire team.

Present these findings to your team members in a post-project meeting documented in. Encourage them to speak, share what went wrong, and voice their ideas about how to do better on similar projects.

The 3 types of project life cycles

Your team is unique—which is why you want to use a process to fit your specific needs. Luckily, there are three types of project life cycles, so see which one could work best for you.

1. Agile model

The [Agile methodology](#) or model emphasizes flexibility and iterative progress. It allows for adjustments and improvements throughout the project. Teams adapt incrementally based on constant feedback.

Agile is popular among [software developer teams](#) who rely on constant back-and-forth collaboration and regularly encounter unforeseen obstacles. And two Agile frameworks to consider are Kanban and [Scrum](#).

Kanban involves visualizing tasks, limiting work in progress, and ensuring a continuous flow of work. This makes it ideal for projects requiring flexibility without strict deadlines.

On the other hand, Scrum operates in time-boxed [sprints](#). Within a sprint, you'll have set goals and regular reviews, which will promote structured iterations and team accountability.

2. Waterfall model

The [Waterfall methodology](#) follows a linear sequential flow, with each phase dependent on the deliverables of the prior ones. Unlike Agile or iterative models, Waterfall is not an [iterative process](#).

This model doesn't allow for flexibility or revisiting previous steps. It's usually best for projects with well-defined requirements and minimal expected changes.

Teams must complete one stage before moving to the next, with little room for changes once a phase is finished. Examples of project types that often follow the Waterfall model include manufacturing, construction, and healthcare projects.

3. Iterative model

The iterative project life cycle is a flexible, cyclical approach where teams develop a product through repeated cycles of prototyping, testing, and refining. Instead of following a strict, linear path, teams build a working version.

This allows teams to gather feedback from customers and stakeholders, and use those insights to improve the product in the next cycle. The process repeats until the desired outcome is achieved.

Unlike rigid, sequential methods, the iterative approach encourages collaboration and problem-solving. This cycle of [continuous improvement](#) makes it especially effective for tackling complex projects and evolving requirements.

It's slightly different from the Agile model in that feedback usually occurs at the end of a milestone. In Agile, feedback is more continuous and frequent.

Why is project life cycle management important?

Effective project life cycle management streamlines processes in several ways.

- Provides structure and clarity:** It breaks down complex projects into manageable phases, making it easier to plan, execute, and monitor.
- Improves planning and control:** Each phase has clear objectives, deliverables, and review points, allowing for better resource allocation and risk management.
- Facilitates communication:** Stakeholders understand what to expect at each stage, improving transparency and alignment.
- Enables progress tracking:** Project managers can measure progress against phase-specific milestones and adjust plans as needed.
- Supports quality assurance:** Defined phases allow for regular reviews and quality checks, reducing the chance of errors going unnoticed.

